

DIA Knowledge Base

CORE PRINCIPLES & HOLISTIC INTERPRETATION

- Drawings provide a window into a child's thoughts and feelings, reflecting an image of their own mind.
- Culture plays a fundamental role, and local cultural symbolism affects the way children draw.
- The drawing tells more about the drawer themselves rather than the subject that was drawn. Even when drawing an object like a tree, the psychological state of the drawer is projected into it.
- Analysis must not rely on hasty conclusions; it should be done by looking at the repetition of elements like color, shapes, and recurring details.
- Interpretations must look at the picture as a whole because the integrated whole is larger than the total sum of its parts (the "preeminence of the whole").
- Age, cognitive development, and the development of motor skills are important factors to consider when analyzing drawings.

PAPER USAGE & TOOLS

- The size of the sheet of paper chosen is an indication of the place a child wants to occupy in general life. Choosing a bigger sheet indicates the child wants to show themselves off. Choosing a smaller sheet of paper shows the child has good concentration.
- Pencils with wide, fat points are favorites with determined children. Pencils with fine points are preferred by children who have more difficulty expressing or asserting themselves.

LINE PRESSURE

- Pen pressure reflects muscle tension, and the degree of the lines indicates the level of energy and tension.
- Faint lines indicate a low level of physical and mental energy, shame, and depression.

SHADING INTENSITY

- If the whole body is shaded, this indicates anxiety.

- If a particular part is shaded, it indicates anxiety associated with that specific part of the body.
- Distorting the shape when shading it is found more often in children who have anxiety and lack compatibility with their environments.

FIGURE SIZE

- Drawing a very big person usually indicates aggression and overactivity. Children who do not adapt well tend to draw exaggerated human figures.
- Drawing a very tiny person shows feelings of incompetence, shame, fear, and depression.

FACIAL FEATURES & HEAD

- **Head:** Exaggerating the head indicates that the child's ego is inflating. Normal children draw the head appropriately for the body.
- **Mouth:** A very large mouth with large size teeth is painted by children who talk a lot or are aggressive, as if they are willing to cut and consume. Normal children draw an appropriate size mouth.
- **Eyes:** Large eyes with a skeptical view are often drawn by disturbed children who feel they are being watched or controlled by others. Eyes drawn in the form of small circles indicate dependence and shallowness of emotion. The deletion of the eyes is evidence of an unwillingness to mix with others.
- **Nose:** Emphasizing the nose holes and enlarging them indicates aggression.

BODY PARTS (NECK & HANDS)

- **Neck:** Painting a too long neck means there are difficulties in achieving wishes and satisfying them. Children who face troubles eliminate the neck completely.
- **Hands:** Stretching hands out indicates a desire to connect to the environment or other persons, or a willingness to help and interact. Large hands are found in drawings of children who steal. Small hands indicate emotions associated with insecurity and helplessness. Abusive or disabled children may always forget to draw hands.

RECURRING SIGNS & RED FLAGS

- There are specific signs that may suggest a problem if observed: recurring feelings of

unease from the drawings, certain parts of figures always missing, hollow or squinting eyes, abnormal crossing out, excessive darkening, tiny drawings confined to a small space, empty figures, or unclosed shapes.

- A child refusing to draw or repeating the exact same drawing within a month also suggests a problem.
- Violent scenes or the appearance of genital organs are not necessarily worrying signs, as long as they are not repeated obsessively.